thousand in number. Soon, they converted to Hindusim and established a kingdom that would last from 1228 till 1826. Mir Jumla's raid of 1662 had hurt them, but they had survived and were steadily clawing back territory. The conflict reached a climax in 1671 in the Battle of Saraighat, not far from modern Guwahati. The Assamese forces were far smaller but their commander cleverly avoided a battle on open ground. Instead, he coaxed the Mughals into a naval battle on the Brahmaputra river, where the smaller and more manoeuvrable Assamese boats won a decisive victory. Although seriously ill, Lachit Borphukan personally led the assault. It was the Indian equivalent of the Battle of Salamis where the ancient Greeks defeated the Persian fleet against overwhelming odds. The myth of Mughal invincibility had been shattered.

The Mughal empire may yet have survived religious bigotry, leaky public finances, Maratha guerrillas, Bundela chieftains and the Assamese navy. The foundations built up by Akbar and his immediate successors were still quite strong, but Aurangzeb committed the ultimate sin—he stayed on the throne too long. He ruled till he died at the age of ninety in 1707. As happened in the case of Ashoka and Feroze Shah Tughlaq, he was followed by a succession of weak rulers culminating in a foreign invasion. In 1739, the Persian army of Nadir Shah occupied Shah Jehan's Delhi and massacred twenty thousand of its citizens. They left with much treasure, including the famous Peacock Throne. With the prestige of the Mughals fast waning, the Marathas occupied large swathes of central India even as the governors of far-flung provinces like Bengal and Hyderabad became virtually independent. Eighteenth-century India dissolved into a chaotic scramble.

A number of foreign players saw the opportunity to extend their influence in the subcontinent. In the North West were the Afghans under Ahmad Shah Durrani, even as the Burmese eyed the North East. In peninsular India, the rivalry between the Dutch and the Portuguese had been replaced by that between the French and the English. Mercenary armies wandered the countryside, feared by rulers and common people alike. For a short while it appeared that the Marathas would replace the Mughals and establish order, but their internal rivalries let them down.